

Long round vs. long non-round vowels in Old Hungarian: diachronic and systemic differences

Typological discussions of the distribution and behaviour of round vowels tend to concentrate on the correlation between backness and rounding (Gordon 2016: 49 sqq) or on rounding harmony within the context of vowel harmony systems (Joseph et al. 2020, Kaun 1995, 2004, Rose & Walker 2011). While both are relevant to Old Hungarian (10th–early 16th c.) too, in this language there is a third — and rather underresearched — aspect of the behaviour of round vs. non-round vowels, and this concerns length. Long round vowels vs. long non-round vowels show a markedly different distribution and they also take part in length alternations in markedly different ways, e.g.

- (i) non-round long vowels systematically alternate with short vowels stem-finally (e.g. [fɒ] ~ [fa:t] ‘tree’ NOM~ACC), whereas round long vowels alternate with surface VC sequences or with short non-round vowels in the same position in many lexemes ([kø:] ~ [køvɛt] ‘stone’ NOM~ACC, [idø:] ~ [idɛjɛ] ‘time’ ~ ‘its time’)
- (ii) non-round long vowels are not permitted in final position of unsuffixed stems/words, whereas round long vowels freely occur finally (e.g. [kø:] ‘stone’, [ɒjto:] ‘door’)
- (iii) non-round long vowels may occur before CC sequences (e.g. [pe:nz] ‘money’, [a:ll] ‘stand’), whereas round long vowels cannot
- (iv) round mid long vowels do not alternate with short vowels stem-internally in the way other long vowels do (e.g. [vi:z] ~ [vizɛt] ‘water’ NOM~ACC).

The typological import of the paper is a demonstration of the fact that long round and long non-round vowels constitute two distinct classes in terms of distribution and behaviour. The theoretical import of the paper is the argument that long round vowels in Old Hungarian (and possibly even in Middle Hungarian) can be analysed as VC sequences phonologically, as opposed to long non-round vowels, which are arguably VV. The diachronic import of the paper is in the effort to disentangle how long the diachronic origins of the long round vowels (indeed often from VC sequences) had an impact on the phonological patterning they show, as well as an explanation for how word-final length alternations were given up for round, but not for non-round, vowels.

The idea itself that long vowels may be analysed as VC sequences is not new, cf. Zirin (1970) or Szigetvári (2016), two representatives of two very different traditions. Our analysis differs from previous analyses in that it shows a language-internal functional distinction in the system of Old Hungarian phonology between VV long vowels and VC long vowels.

References

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